



important inventions ever, the vaccine has literally saved millions of lives, and continues to enable people across the world to lead normal, healthy lives. Infact, we might not have existed as a race if not for vaccines.

The invention of the vaccine dates back to the long history of infectious diseases in humans. There is evidence that the Chinese and the Indians advocated smallpox inoculation as early as the 16th century. However, the first vaccine is credited to Edward Jenner, who made a smallpox vaccine in 1796. He realised that milkmaids, who worked with cows, did not develop the disease, whereas all the others did. After further research he concluded that the cowpox virus (contracted from cows) gave its victims immunity to smallpox. He then administered the cowpox virus to a boy, and once the cowpox symptoms died off, he injected in him the smallpox virus. The boy, however never became ill with smallpox, and this experiment is known as the world's first vaccine. Word of this spread like fire, and in only 5 years, more than 100,000 people had been vaccinated. In 1885, Louis Pasteur made a breakthrough in vaccination, by making a vaccine against rabies, the first vaccine not made for smallpox. Slowly, vaccines for various diseases were made, and vaccination had become so widespread that by 1980, smallpox as a disease had become eradicated. Diseases such as polio, measles, mumps, hepatitis, chickenpox, pneumonia have all declined by great amounts thanks to the introduction of vaccines against them, with some such as polio even close to eradication. Now, mil-